Inferences

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Functional English (SS1012)

Implied Main Ideas

- An **implied main idea** is only suggested; it is not clearly stated in one sentence.
- To figure out an implied main idea, we must look at the supporting details.

IMPLIED MAIN IDEAS IN PARAGRAPHS

To find the main idea when it is not directly stated, we must ask the same questions we've already used to find main ideas:

- Who or what is the paragraph about? (What is the **topic**?)
- What is the **main point** the author is trying to make about the topic?

When we think we know the main point, we can test it by asking this question:

- Does *all or most* of the material in the paragraph support this idea?

IMPLIED MAIN IDEAS IN PARAGRAPHS

Read the paragraph below. Then answer the question.

Slashing their swords wildly, swordfish swim through schools of fish, trying to slice as many as possible; then they feast. When hooked by fishermen, they have been known to fight nonstop for three or four hours. They have pulled some fishermen to their deaths, and if they are not clubbed senseless when captured, they will slash fishermen on deck. A puncture wound by a swordfish bill means a severe and nearly instantaneous infection. Their sword, which is a bony extension of the upper jaw, is deadly sharp on the sides and can grow to a length of four or five feet. It is a weapon backed up by five hundred pounds of sleek, muscular fish. Swordfish have even been known to attack boats, driving their swords right through the hull and at times sinking them.

The topic of the paragraph is "swordfish." Choose the point the author is trying to make about swordfish.

A. Swordfish will attack entire schools of fish.

B. Swordfish will fight for hours when hooked and have even pulled some fishermen to their deaths.

C. A swordfish bill can cause severe infections and even sink a boat.

D. Swordfish are aggressive, dangerous fish.

IMPLIED MAIN IDEAS IN PARAGRAPHS

- When you read, you often have to **infer** — figure out on your own—the author's unstated main idea.
- The implied main idea you come up with should cover all or most of the details in the paragraph.

Inferences

- Many important ideas in reading are not stated directly.
- Discovering these ideas is called **making inferences** or **drawing conclusions**.

What is an Inference?

An inference is an assumption that you make about something that you see, read, or experience.

- It is based on all of the information that you have available at that time.
- It is not necessarily a correct guess, but it is an educated one.

Everyday Inferences

Here are some inferences that you probably make on a daily basis.

If your professor writes information on the board during a lecture → You infer that it is important information that you may need later.

If your son or daughter runs in the house holding their knee and crying → You infer that they have somehow hurt their knee.

You may not always be correct in your inferences, but they are assumptions that you make based on the given clues.

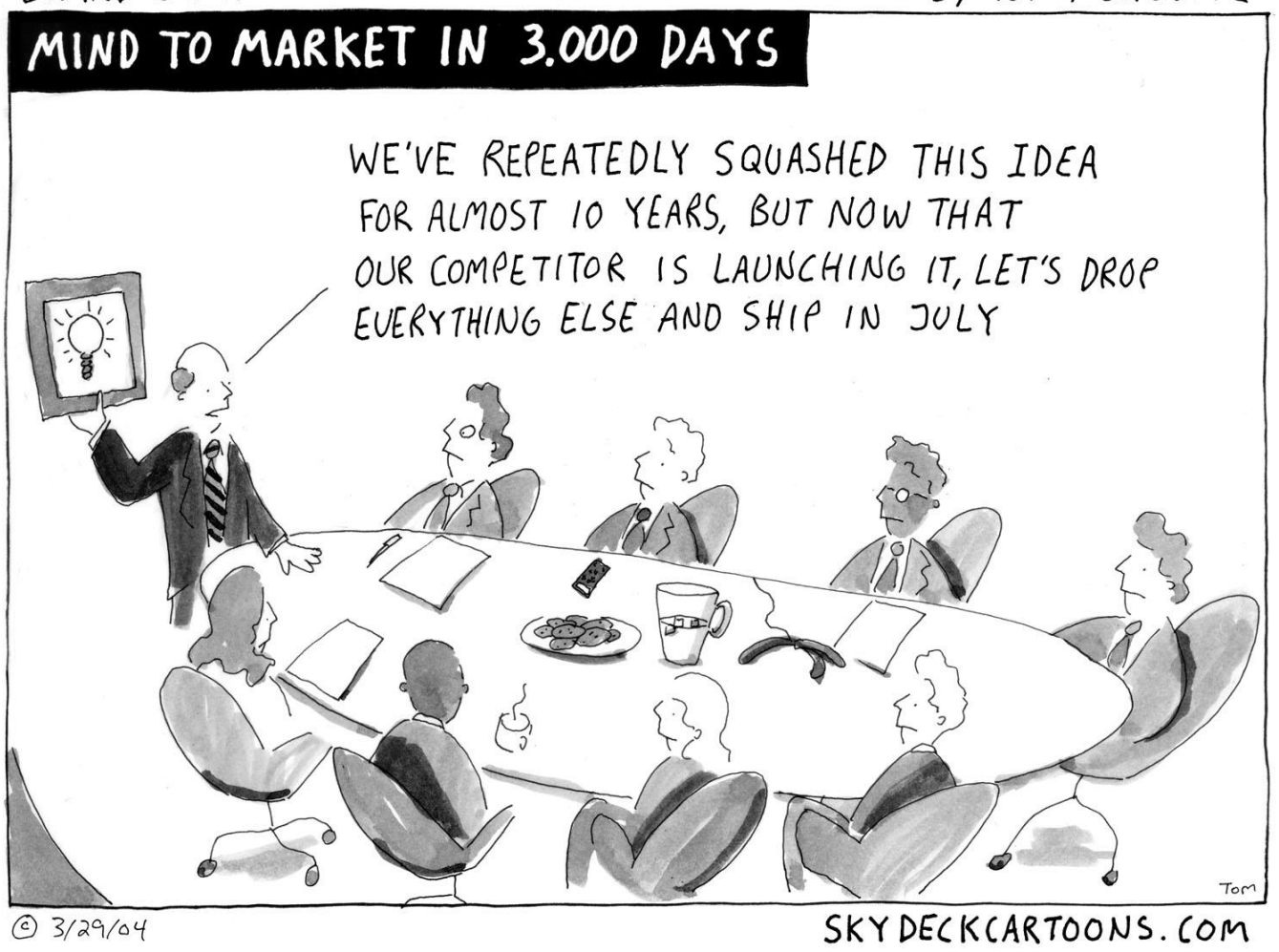
Inferences: Take a Guess

You already know how to make everyday inferences!



Lets look at a few scenarios and infer about what is going on.

Inferences: Take Another Guess?



1. Where are they?
2. Who is the man standing in the front of the room?
3. Is this company on the cutting edge?

Inferences: Take a Guess?

Lets look a little bit closer and evaluate your assumptions.

Is this company on the cutting edge?

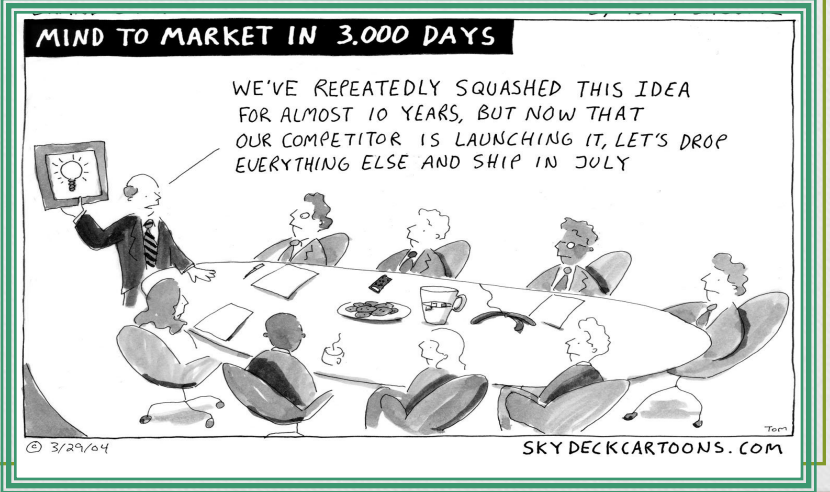
We can infer by his dialogue that they are behind the competition.

Where are they?

The table and topic, reveal that they are in a corporate board room.

Who is the man standing in the front of the room?

Because he is in the front of the room standing we would infer that he is the boss.



Inferences: Take One More Guess?



1. What season is it in this picture?
2. What is the person doing?
3. What socio-economic group does she belong to? Lower Class? Middle class? Upper Class?

Inferences: Take a Guess?

Lets look a little bit closer and evaluate your assumptions.

What socio-economic group does she belong to?

Based on the quality of the clothing and ornament, we can rule out lower class. Based on the known information any further inference would be a stretch.

What is the person doing?

She is holding the Ornament. We could infer further that she is decorating a Christmas tree.

What season is it in this picture?

The Santa hat and Ornament reveal that it is winter.



Inferences: Character Personalities & Emotions

Author's often use word pictures to give you clues about the personalities and emotions of the characters. For Instance:

If the character is shown refusing to be controlled by others such as their parents, boss, or other authority figure → We infer that they are **rebellious**.

If the character storms out of the room, slamming the door behind them → We infer that they are **angry**.

If we see them doing things that show good character in front of other, but exhibiting negative traits when alone → We infer that they are **deceptive**.

{Click mouse to continue}

Inferences: Take a Guess Part 2

**Read the following paragraph,
and answer the questions that follow.**

Geoffrey awoke early that morning, for fear of being late for his appointment. He showered, brushed his hair, and put on his best suit. He stuck extra ink pens and pencils into his brief case. He did not want to leave anything to chance. He knew that if he did not get a job soon, Martha would have to leave the children and go back to work.

{Click mouse to continue}

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1. What kind of appointment is Geoffrey getting ready for?
   a) He is going job hunting.
   b) He is going to a board meeting for his job.
   c) He is going to a job interview.

2. Who is Martha?

a) His mother.

b) His wife.

c) His daughter.

---

3. Which of these personality traits best fits Geoffrey?

a) Responsible

b) Optimistic

c) Selfish

4. What is Geoffrey's motive for waking up early ?

a) To be an example for his children.

b) To be on time for his appointment.

c) He does not want Martha to go back to work.

{Click mouse to continue}

5. What might he need extra pens and pencils for at his appointment ?

a) To fill out necessary forms.

b) To take notes on the speaker.

c) To hand out as advertisements for his firm.

{Click mouse to continue}

Inferences: ANSWERS

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INFERENCES

Which **inference** is more logically based on the information in this cartoon?

A. The man was probably working on a home improvement or repair project.

B. The man deliberately ruined the woman's pan.



INFERENCES

Which **inference** is more logically based on the information in this cartoon?



A. The man was probably working on a home improvement or repair project.

Since the man was using a kitchen pan as a hammer, he must have been somewhere where there is a kitchen—probably his and the woman's home.

B. The man deliberately ruined the woman's pan.

The man's explanation—he couldn't find his hammer—suggests that he simply needed something to hammer with. Nothing suggests that he intentionally ruined the pan.

INFERENCES

Which **inference** is more logically based on the information in this cartoon?

C. The woman is upset that the man has used her pan as a hammer.

D. The man realizes that the woman is angry at him for using her good pan as a hammer.



INFERENCES

Which **inference** is more logically based on the information in this cartoon?



C. The woman is upset that the man has used her pan as a hammer.

The woman's final comment strongly suggests that she is angry and needs to let out her anger, quite possibly by hammering the person who ruined her pan.

D. The man realizes that the woman is angry at him for using her good pan as a hammer.

Nothing in the man's body language or words indicates that he realizes the woman is angry with him.

INFERENCES IN READING

Which **inference** is more firmly based on the information in the passage?

Jim Johnson panicked when he came home from work to find his neighbor's pet rabbit dead and in the jaws of his German shepherd, Fido. Johnson took the filthy, slightly chewed-up bunny into his house, washed it with care, and then used the blow dryer to restore its fur as best he could. A short time later he secretly put the rabbit back into its outdoor cage.

The next day, Jim's neighbor stopped him as they were both doing yard work. "Did you hear that Thumper died?"

"Uh, no," stammered Johnson.

"We went out a couple days ago and found him dead. What's really weird, though, is that the day after we buried him, we went outside and discovered that someone had dug him up, given him a bath, styled his fur, and put him back into his cage!"

Which **inference** is more firmly based on the information in the passage?

A. Johnson's neighbor had children who took care of the rabbit.

B. Fido had probably dug up the rabbit's grave.

C. The neighbor was convinced that Johnson had dug up the rabbit.

D. Jim Johnson assumed his dog had killed the rabbit.

E. The rabbit had been very sick.

INFERENCES IN READING

Which **inference** is more firmly based on the information in the passage?

Early one morning, a man was walking along a sandy, deserted beach. At least he thought it was deserted. As he gazed ahead of him, he noticed that there was another human figure in sight. It was a boy who kept bending down, picking something up, and throwing it into the sea. He repeated the movement again and again and again.

As the man drew near, he saw that the sand surrounding the boy was covered with starfish that had been washed in by the waves. It was these stranded starfish that the boy was throwing into the water.

"Why are you doing that?" the man asked.

Not pausing, the boy replied, "The tide is going out, and the sun is rising. Soon the heat will be too much for the starfish, and they will die."

The man shook his head tolerantly. "My dear boy," he said. "There are miles of beach and hundreds, maybe thousands of starfish. You can't save them all. What you're doing can't make a difference!"

The boy listened politely, then picked up the next starfish and threw it in the water. "It makes a difference for this one," he answered.

A. The boy knows he cannot save all the starfish.

B. The man believes the boy's efforts are admirable.

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The boy listened politely, then picked up the next starfish and threw it in the water. "It makes a difference for this one," he answered.

A. The boy knows he cannot save all the starfish.
The boy doesn't show any surprise when the man tells him he can't save all the starfish. Also, the boy's obvious understanding of the shore cycles makes it clear he knows how few starfish he could save. He indicates he still wants to save the ones he can.

B. The man believes the boy's efforts are admirable.
The man is "tolerant" of what the boy is doing, but he suggests the boy's actions are pointless.

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C. The man decides to help save some of the stranded starfish.

D. The boy believes that a little help is better than nothing.

INFERENCES IN READING

Guidelines for Making Inferences in Reading

1. Never lose sight of **available information**.

   As much as possible, base your inferences on facts.

2. Use your **background information** and **experience** to help you in making inferences.

   The more you know about a subject, the better your inferences are likely to be.

3. Consider the **alternatives**.

   Don't simply accept the first inference that comes to mind.

INFERENCES IN TABLES AND GRAPHS

- Just as pictures and reading material require inferences, so do **tables** and **graphs**.
- To infer the ideas presented in tables and graphs, you must **consider all the information presented**.

2. Reading Tables

- **Step 1:** Identify headings, units, categories.
- **Step 2:** Compare values across rows/columns.
- **Step 3:** Look for patterns (increase, decrease, stability).
- **Step 4:** Infer what the data suggests beyond what is written.

Example Table: Internet Usage (Hours/Week)

Student	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Ahmad	10	12	15	18
Sara	5	6	6	7
Bilal	8	10	12	16

- **Fact:** Ahmad increased from 10 to 18 hours in 4 weeks.
- **Inference:** Ahmad may be spending more time on assignments or social media.
- **Inference:** Sara's usage is steady → she may have consistent habits.

Skills for Making Inferences

- **Look for patterns** (increase, decrease, fluctuation).
- **Connect cause and effect** (Why might this trend exist?).
- **Use prior knowledge** (Relate data to real-world context).
    - **Ask questions**:
        - What does this mean?
        - What might happen next?
        - Why is this important?

“Glued” Link

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rW
2g5cwxrqQ

Questions for "Glued"

1. How does the mother feel when she looks out of the window?
2. Why does the mother open the curtains?
3. Why does the son go upstairs?
4. How does she feel when she sees her son playing the Gameboy on the stairs?
5. Why did she throw the items away?
6. Why does she laugh as she is burning the items?
7. How must the mother feel when she looks out the window the next morning?
8. Why does she grab the baseball glove?
9. What is the boy doing outside?
10. How must the mother feel?